

**WHY SOME REVISIONIST STATES BUILD AND OTHERS BREAK:
DOMESTIC CONSTRAINTS, TIME HORIZONS, AND
STRATEGIC CHOICE IN CHINA AND RUSSIA**

A Thesis By

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Abstract:

This thesis examines why the strategic form of revisionist behavior varies across episodes. Existing scholarship shows that revisionism is not a single or self-evident category, but it pays less attention to why some revisionist challenges take institutional forms while others take coercive ones. I argue that domestic conditions, especially economic performance and leader political security, shape leaders' time horizons and risk calculations, which in turn influence whether revisionist behavior takes the form of institution-building or coercion. To evaluate this argument, the thesis employs a comparative case study with process tracing, focusing on China's creation of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and Russia's annexation of Crimea. The analysis suggests that relatively permissive domestic conditions in China were more compatible with a longer-horizon strategy of institution-building, whereas weaker economic conditions and greater political insecurity in Russia were more compatible with a shorter-horizon logic in which coercion became politically more attractive. The thesis does not claim that domestic conditions replace systemic, geopolitical, or ideational explanations. Rather, it shows that domestic conditions help explain why different strategic forms of revisionist behavior became politically feasible and attractive across these two episodes.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

This thesis addresses a central puzzle in contemporary international politics: states commonly described as revisionist do not challenge international order in a uniform way. Some pursue change through multilateral institution-building and governance design, while others rely on coercion, force-backed intervention, or territorial revision. Recent scholarship has therefore argued that revisionism should not be treated as a single or self-evident category, but should instead be disaggregated by both the object of contestation and the means through which change is pursued (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). Building on this insight, this thesis asks why the strategic form of revisionist behavior varies across episodes. I argue that domestic conditions, especially economic performance and leader political security, shape leaders' time horizons and risk calculations, which in turn influence the strategic form revisionist behavior takes, whether through institution-building or coercion (Blake, 2013; Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). To evaluate this argument, the thesis examines two contrasting cases: China's creation of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and Russia's annexation of Crimea (Allison, 2014; Chin, 2016; Götz, 2015; Hale, 2018; Ren, 2016).

The Puzzle

Recent scholarship makes clear that revisionism is not a single posture. Cooley et al. (2019) argue that one-dimensional accounts blur important distinctions between challenges to international order and challenges to the distribution of capabilities. He et al. (2021) likewise show that revisionism can take softer forms oriented toward gradual institutional reform and new norms, which means that analyses focused primarily on military conquest or overt coercion may overlook an important part of contemporary revisionist statecraft. Kustermans et al. (2023) further emphasize that revisionism is context-dependent and must be judged in relation to the legitimate ends and means of a particular

international order. Taken together, this literature suggests that scholars should pay closer attention not only to whether states are revisionist, but also to how the strategic form of revisionist behavior varies.

This puzzle can be seen clearly in two prominent cases. China's creation of the AIIB is widely treated as a case of institution-building through multilateral rules, treaty-based design, and governance innovation in development finance (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b; Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). Russia's annexation of Crimea, by contrast, is widely understood as a coercive, force-backed challenge to prevailing rules and norms rather than a case of institutional innovation (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016). Both episodes are often discussed as major-power challenges to aspects of the existing order, yet they differ sharply in strategic form (Allison, 2014; Chin, 2016; Götz, 2015; Ren, 2016).

The puzzle, then, is not simply whether these states can be described as revisionist. The more precise question is why the strategic form of revisionist behavior took such different forms across these episodes. Why did China pursue a revisionist strategy through multilateral institution-building, while Russia pursued a revisionist strategy through coercive territorial action? Existing scholarship provides increasingly strong conceptual tools for distinguishing varieties of revisionism, but it is less clear about what shapes leaders' selection among alternative revisionist repertoires (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). This thesis proposes that domestic conditions, especially economic performance and leader political security, shape leaders' time horizons and risk calculations and thereby help explain variation in the strategic form revisionist behavior takes across these two episodes (Blake, 2013; Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012).

Research Question and Argument

The central research question of this thesis is straightforward: why do some revisionist episodes take institution-building forms while others take coercive forms? In answering this question, I argue that domestic conditions, especially economic performance and leader political security, influence the strategic form revisionist behavior takes by shaping leaders' time horizons and risk calculations (Blake, 2013; Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). When domestic conditions are

relatively favorable and leaders are more politically secure, they are better able to tolerate delayed and indirect returns (Blake, 2013; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012), making slower, legitimacy-oriented strategies more feasible. When economic conditions weaken and political insecurity increases, leaders face stronger incentives to seek rapid, visible, and politically salient gains (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012), which can make coercive strategies more attractive despite their international costs (Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017; He et al., 2021). This argument is not intended to replace systemic or geopolitical explanations. Rather, it complements them by identifying a domestic mechanism that may help explain why leaders choose one strategic form of revisionist behavior rather than another. More precisely, the thesis does not argue that domestic conditions alone cause revisionist behavior or that they override issue-specific constraints. Its narrower claim is that domestic conditions help explain variation in the strategic form revisionist behavior takes across particular episodes.

Why It Matters and Contribution

Explaining variation in the strategic form of revisionist behavior matters because different strategic forms carry different implications for international order and political stability. Coercion, especially when it involves territorial seizure and force-backed intervention, is associated with acute escalation risks, legal contestation, and norm violation, as the Crimea case illustrates (Allison, 2014). Institution-building strategies may be less immediately escalatory, but they can still reshape rules, authority, and distributional outcomes in consequential ways (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021). In other words, revisionism pursued through institutions may appear less dramatic in the short term while still transforming important aspects of international order over time (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021).

The AIIB case shows why institutional strategies deserve serious analytical attention. China did not pursue revisionist behavior in this episode through direct military coercion, but through the creation of a new multilateral institution that could influence development finance, governance practices, and regional authority over time (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). The Crimea case

highlights the opposite pattern. Research on post-Crimea opinion dynamics suggests that coercive external action can generate immediate and politically salient domestic benefits, making it plausible that domestic incentives matter to leaders' strategic choices in authoritarian settings (Hale, 2018, 2022). By placing these two episodes side by side, this thesis shows why it is analytically insufficient to ask only whether a state is revisionist. It is also necessary to ask what strategic form revisionist behavior takes and why that form is selected.

This thesis contributes to the literature in three main ways. First, it contributes to revisionism scholarship by focusing on variation in the strategic form of revisionist behavior rather than treating revisionism as a single posture (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). In doing so, it builds on work that distinguishes between institutional and coercive forms of contestation and adds a domestic-mechanism explanation for why leaders may choose one strategic form over the other. Second, it contributes to research on institutional contestation by treating the AIIB as a meaningful case of revisionist institution-building and by taking institutional strategies seriously as instruments of geopolitical contestation without assuming that they are either purely cooperative or purely hostile (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Goddard, 2018; Ren, 2016). Third, it contributes to the literature on Russia's foreign policy and domestic politics by linking coercion to domestic political incentives while remaining cautious about monocausal claims in a case also shaped by geopolitical and ideational factors (Allison, 2014; Götz, 2015; Hale, 2018, 2022; Person, 2017).

More broadly, this thesis brings together two literatures that are often discussed separately: scholarship that disaggregates revisionism and scholarship that emphasizes domestic political constraints in foreign policy. Putnam's (1988) two-level framework shows that international strategy is shaped by domestic political pressures, while Svolik's (2012) work in comparative authoritarian politics highlights the importance of elite and mass threats to leaders' survival. Bringing these insights together helps explain not only whether leaders pursue revisionist change, but also why they may prefer one strategic form over another.

The remainder of the thesis proceeds as follows. Chapter 2 develops the theoretical framework and research design, clarifying the main concepts, variables, and causal mechanism. Chapter 3 examines China's creation of the AIIB as a case of institution-building and evaluates whether the proposed mechanism is consistent with the sequence and context of that strategic choice. Chapter 4 analyzes Russia's annexation of Crimea as a case of coercion and assesses whether weaker domestic conditions and greater political insecurity help explain the attraction of coercive action. Chapter 5 brings the two cases into direct comparison, clarifies what the thesis can and cannot explain, considers its limitations and broader implications, and concludes by reflecting on what the findings suggest about revisionist strategy and contemporary international order.

CHAPTER 2

THEORY, HYPOTHESES, AND RESEARCH DESIGN

This chapter develops the thesis's core argument and explains how it will be evaluated. Recent scholarship shows that revisionism can take different forms and operate through different means, but it is less precise about why leaders choose one revisionist strategy rather than another in particular episodes (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). The argument advanced here is narrower: domestic conditions help shape the strategic form revisionist behavior takes by influencing leaders' time horizons and risk calculations. The chapter therefore defines the dependent variable, specifies the mechanism and hypotheses, and explains the comparative design and process-tracing strategy.

Conceptual Framework and Scope Conditions

The dependent variable in this thesis is the dominant strategic form of revisionist behavior in a specific episode. At a broad level, the thesis distinguishes between two strategic forms: institution-building and coercion (Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021). Institution-building refers to efforts to reshape aspects of international order through the creation, redesign, or strategic use of formal multilateral institutions, rules, and governance arrangements (Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021). Coercion refers to efforts to pursue revisionist change through force-backed intervention, territorial revision, or other highly visible forms of pressure that challenge prevailing rules more directly (He et al., 2021). The purpose of this distinction is not to claim that all revisionist behavior fits neatly into only two categories. Rather, it is to establish a workable contrast for explaining why different strategic forms emerged in the two focal episodes examined here.

Within this framework, the AIIB episode is treated as a case of institution-building because it centers on the creation of a new multilateral development bank through negotiated rules, formal membership, and treaty-based governance design (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). The

Crimea episode is treated as a case of coercion because it involved force-backed territorial revision and contested legal justification in a manner widely characterized as rule-breaking intervention (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016). The thesis therefore explains variation in strategic form across episodes, not whether a state is revisionist in some general or fixed sense. This scope condition is important because the same state may rely on different repertoires in different contexts.

Domestic Mechanism and Hypotheses

The argument of this thesis centers on two domestic conditions: economic performance and leader political security. Economic performance matters because it shapes both material resources and the domestic political environment in which leaders assess patience, political payoff, and the costs of waiting (Blake, 2013; Putnam, 1988). Leader political security matters because it captures the leader's vulnerability to elite and mass threats, which affects survival incentives, urgency, and tolerance for risk (Svolik, 2012). These variables are not treated as deterministic causes. Instead, they are treated as domestic conditions that shape how leaders evaluate alternative revisionist options.

The proposed mechanism links these domestic conditions to strategic choice through time horizons and risk calculations. When domestic conditions are relatively favorable and leaders are more politically secure, they are better able to tolerate delayed and indirect returns (Blake, 2013; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). Under those conditions, slower and less immediately dramatic strategies become more politically sustainable (Blake, 2013; Edelstein, 2017; Putnam, 1988). When economic conditions weaken and political insecurity increases, leaders face stronger incentives to seek rapid, visible, and politically salient gains (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). Under those conditions, coercive options may become more attractive even when they carry substantial international risks (Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017). The mechanism therefore does not claim that domestic politics mechanically determines strategy. It claims that domestic conditions affect how leaders perceive urgency, acceptable risk, and the trade-off between delayed and immediate returns.

More specifically, the mechanism operates through three linked considerations. First, domestic conditions shape the political costs of delay. Leaders who are more secure can more easily wait for long-run returns, whereas insecure leaders face greater pressure for immediate results (Blake, 2013; Putnam, 1988). Second, domestic conditions shape the value of visible payoff. Leaders operating under economic weakness or political vulnerability may place greater value on strategies that generate rapid and salient political effects (Dvir, 2021). Third, domestic conditions shape tolerance for international risk. Leaders facing shorter time horizons may become more willing to accept the external costs of coercive action if such action promises domestic political benefits (Dvir, 2021; Edelstein, 2017).

From this argument follow two hypotheses. H_1 predicts that leaders facing relatively favorable economic performance and relatively high political security will be more likely to pursue institution-building rather than coercive strategies. H_2 predicts that leaders facing deteriorating economic performance and relatively low political security will be more likely to pursue coercive rather than institution-building strategies. These hypotheses are intentionally limited in scope. They are designed to explain variation in the strategic form of revisionist behavior across specific episodes rather than the existence of revisionism in general.

Operationalization and Case Logic

To evaluate this argument systematically, the thesis operationalizes the variables in a transparent and comparable way across the two cases. The dependent variable, the strategic form of revisionist behavior, is coded at the episode level. The AIIB episode is coded as institution-building because it centers on the creation of a new multilateral development bank through negotiated rules, formal membership, and treaty-based governance design (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). The Crimea episode is coded as coercion because it involved force-backed territorial revision and contested legal justification in a manner widely characterized as rule-breaking intervention (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016).

The first independent variable, economic performance, is operationalized descriptively using the World Bank's GDP growth (annual %) series within a standardized pre-treatment window for each country (World Bank, n.d.-a, n.d.-b). This thesis does not treat GDP growth as an exhaustive measure of domestic economic pressures. Rather, it uses GDP growth as a transparent and comparable baseline indicator of whether the broader macroeconomic environment appears relatively permissive or relatively constrained within each case's pre-treatment window. The indicator is therefore interpreted comparatively and contextually rather than as a fixed universal threshold.

The second independent variable, leader political security, is operationalized as a multidimensional concept grounded in comparative authoritarian politics, especially the distinction between elite and mass threats emphasized by Svolik (2012). In this thesis, leader political security is assessed through three dimensions: elite threat, mass contention, and legitimacy stress. Elite threat refers to signs of elite disunity, elite challenge, or elite-management pressure. Mass contention refers to protest activity, mobilization, or public pressure that may increase political vulnerability. Legitimacy stress refers to evidence that the leader's political standing, authority, or public support is under visible strain. These dimensions are used as an adapted common rubric across both cases in order to improve comparability and reduce the risk that one case is interpreted loosely while the other is interpreted more strictly.

The case logic is comparative but deliberately narrow. Rather than treating China and Russia as fixed national types, the thesis examines two focal episodes that involve major powers widely discussed in scholarship on revisionism and international order and that vary clearly on the dependent variable: the AIIB episode is treated here as institution-building, whereas the Crimea episode is treated as coercion (Allison, 2014; Chin, 2016; He et al., 2021; Ren, 2016). Both episodes are also substantively important because each illuminates a major form of order contestation in contemporary international politics (Allison, 2014; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). At the same time, the thesis explicitly recognizes that the cases differ in issue area. The claim is therefore not that issue type is irrelevant, but that issue type alone does

not fully explain why one particular strategic form became more politically sustainable and attractive at those moments.

To improve comparability, the thesis uses a standardized three-year pre-treatment window anchored to a focal public commitment point in each case. For AIIB, the thesis treats the October 24, 2014 signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) as the focal public commitment point because it marked the project's formal multilateral consolidation, even though the Chinese leadership had publicly proposed the initiative in late 2013; this produces a pre-treatment window of 2012–2014 (AIIB, 2015a; Ren, 2016). For Crimea, the focal commitment point is best understood as the late-February to March-2014 decision sequence through which Russia moved onto the annexation pathway, which produces a pre-treatment window of 2011–2013 (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016). This pre-treatment logic helps ensure that the comparison focuses on the domestic conditions that preceded the strategic choice rather than on downstream consequences of the choice itself.

Two cases cannot establish a universal law, and this thesis does not claim to do so. The value of the design lies instead in disciplined comparison. By asking the same analytical questions in each case and by using the same conceptual rubric for domestic conditions, the thesis seeks to clarify whether the proposed mechanism holds across sharply different revisionist repertoires and where its limits may lie (George & Bennett, 2005; Beach & Pedersen, 2019).

Process-Tracing Strategy and Evidence

Process tracing is central to the design because the thesis is trying to assess an underlying causal process rather than a surface association between variables. Following Collier (2011), process tracing is used here as a tool of within-case causal inference that emphasizes sequence, diagnostic evidence, and the evaluation of causal claims. Following George and Bennett (2005), the comparison is conducted as a structured, focused comparison: the same core questions are asked of both cases, and the evidence is interpreted in relation to the same theoretical expectations. Beach and Pedersen (2019) and Bennett and

Checkel (2015) further emphasize that process tracing is strongest when hypothesized mechanisms are clearly specified and temporally ordered evidence is evaluated against rival explanations.

In this thesis, each empirical chapter follows the same analytical sequence. First, it identifies the relevant pre-treatment domestic conditions, focusing on economic performance and leader political security. Second, it examines evidence of time-horizon and risk logic, asking whether the domestic context appears more compatible with patience and delayed returns or with urgency and demand for visible payoff. Third, it identifies the strategic commitment point, that is, the moment at which the leader publicly or practically commits to the focal strategic path. Fourth, it analyzes the observed strategic form, showing whether the episode is best treated here as institution-building or coercion. Fifth, it evaluates rival explanations, especially systemic, geopolitical, ideational, or issue-specific accounts, in order to assess whether the domestic mechanism adds explanatory value beyond those alternatives.

This phase-based strategy matters because the mechanism cannot be observed directly. Leaders do not usually state their time horizons or risk calculations in a clean and measurable way. The task, therefore, is not to rely on any single piece of evidence, but to assess whether the sequence of evidence is broadly consistent with the hypothesized mechanism and whether rival explanations alone are sufficient to account for the observed strategic form (Beach & Pedersen, 2019; Bennett & Checkel, 2015; Collier, 2011; George & Bennett, 2005). Observable expectations should therefore appear before, not only after, the focal strategic commitment. Post-choice outcomes such as institutional influence or rally effects matter as corroborating evidence, but they are not treated as self-sufficient proof of *ex ante* motivation.

The evidentiary strategy reflects this goal. The thesis relies primarily on peer-reviewed scholarship for interpretive analysis and on selected official and institutional sources for key factual benchmarks. AIIB official materials are used to establish the institutional sequence and formal milestones of the bank's creation (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b, 2016). World Bank GDP growth series provide standardized macroeconomic indicators used descriptively in the pre-treatment windows (World Bank,

n.d.-a, n.d.-b). For Russia, International Monetary Fund (IMF) and World Bank materials help anchor claims about economic slowdown in the pre-Crimea period and about deterioration in the broader context around and after the Crimea episode (IMF, 2014, 2015; World Bank, 2013). These sources are not treated as self-sufficient proof of causation. Rather, they are used to reconstruct context, sequence, and mechanism-consistent evidence as carefully as the available record allows.

The limitations of this approach should be acknowledged clearly. Some elements of leader political security, especially in authoritarian systems, are inherently difficult to observe directly. The China case is particularly challenging in this respect because leader political security often must be inferred indirectly through indicators such as elite-management efforts, anti-corruption and discipline campaigns, social-control practices, and broader signs of regime consolidation or vulnerability (Shirk, 2018; Wang & Zeng, 2016). The Russia case offers more direct evidence of pre-choice insecurity and post-choice rally effects, especially through the legacy of the 2011–2012 protest wave and the documented popularity surge after Crimea (Hale, 2018, 2022; Person, 2017). Even there, however, the thesis does not claim monocausality. For that reason, the empirical chapters adopt a cautious standard of inference: the question is whether the evidence is consistent with the proposed domestic mechanism, not whether the mechanism can be established as the only cause.

Taken together, this design allows the thesis to move beyond description alone toward a more explicit assessment of causal mechanism. By combining a focused comparison of two substantively important cases with a mechanism-centered process-tracing strategy, the thesis seeks to evaluate whether domestic conditions help explain why revisionist behavior sometimes takes the form of institution-building and at other times takes the form of coercion.

CHAPTER 3

CHINA AND THE AIIB: INSTITUTION-BUILDING AS REVISIONIST STRATEGY

This chapter examines China's creation of the AIIB as a case of institution-building and asks whether the episode fits the domestic-mechanism argument developed in Chapter 2. Its central question is why a slow, legal, and multilateral pathway became politically feasible and strategically attractive for the Chinese leadership in the 2012–2014 pre-treatment period. To answer that question, the chapter traces the choice of strategic form in the AIIB episode and evaluates whether the available evidence is consistent with a longer-horizon, legitimacy-oriented logic shaped by relatively permissive domestic conditions. Because the China case provides only indirect evidence on leader political security, the claim remains cautious: domestic conditions are treated not as the sole explanation for the AIIB initiative, but as part of the explanation for why institution-building was politically sustainable in this episode.

Why the AIIB Is Treated Here as Revisionism by Institutional Means

Before examining the AIIB as the focal strategic choice, a brief clarification is necessary. This thesis does not treat revisionism as a fixed national essence, nor does it assume that all revisionist behavior takes coercive or military form. Instead, following recent scholarship, it treats revisionism as a category that must be disaggregated by both the object of contestation and the means through which change is pursued (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). On that basis, the AIIB is treated here not as a case of coercive revisionism, but as a case of revisionist contestation pursued through institutional means (Chin, 2016; He et al., 2021; Ren, 2016). The claim is therefore episode-specific and analytically bounded: it concerns the strategic form of China's challenge in this particular episode, not the total character of Chinese foreign policy.

The reason this classification is defensible is that the AIIB was not simply a cooperative development initiative in a politically neutral sense. China sought to create a new multilateral

development bank with formal membership, negotiated governance rules, and treaty-based institutional design, thereby opening an alternative channel through which influence over development finance and aspects of regional and global governance could be exercised (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b, 2016; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016; Yang, 2016). Existing scholarship also shows that revisionist states may pursue change not only through force, but through softer forms of institutional engagement, reform, competition, and alternative governance arrangements (Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023). In that sense, the AIIB is best understood here as an attempt to reshape parts of the existing order through a legal, multilateral, and organizational route rather than through overt coercion (Chin, 2016; He et al., 2021; Ren, 2016; Yang, 2016).

At the same time, this thesis adopts a cautious interpretation of what that means. It does not claim that the AIIB was purely hostile, that it aimed to overthrow the existing international order, or that revisionism is the only valid interpretation of the case. The literature also plausibly interprets the AIIB as a response to frustration with slow reform in existing institutions, as a response to development-finance gaps, as a status-seeking project, and as an instrument of regional economic statecraft (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Humphrey, 2015; Wilson, 2019; Yang, 2016). The narrower claim advanced here is that, in its initial formulation and strategic logic, the AIIB represented a meaningful effort to alter patterns of institutional influence and governance through the creation of a new multilateral mechanism (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016; Yang, 2016). For the purposes of this thesis, that is sufficient to justify treating the AIIB episode as revisionism by institutional means and to ask why this particular strategic form became politically feasible and attractive.

The AIIB as the Focal Strategic Choice

Once the AIIB is defined as a case of revisionism pursued through institutional means, the next analytic question is temporal and methodological: when did the Chinese leadership move onto that

institutional pathway? The institutional sequence is well established. The initiative was publicly proposed in 2013, the MoU was signed on October 24, 2014, the Articles of Agreement were signed on June 29, 2015, and the charter entered into force on December 25, 2015 (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b, 2016; Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Ren, 2016). For the purposes of process tracing, however, the key issue is not the institution's entire later life cycle, but the point at which this institutional route was selected and publicly committed to.

In that sense, the October 2014 MoU is the clearest public commitment point, while the earlier 2013 announcement marks the moment when the institutional option entered China's strategic repertoire (AIIB, 2015a; Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Ren, 2016). This narrower focus is methodologically important because it keeps the chapter centered on the selection of strategic form rather than simply describing the institution after it had already been chosen. The chapter therefore asks why the Chinese leadership, facing the domestic conditions of 2012–2014, selected this institutional route instead of a more coercive or directly confrontational one.

Pre-Choice Domestic Conditions: Economic Moderation, Reform, and Development Priorities

The first component of the argument concerns economic performance. The theoretical claim is not that economic growth directly causes institution-building. Rather, the argument is that economic conditions shape the political environment in which leaders evaluate patience, the domestic sustainability of external strategy, and the acceptability of delayed returns (Putnam, 1988). In the Chinese case, the relevant pre-treatment window does not indicate acute macroeconomic crisis. World Bank data and the World Bank's June 2014 China Economic Update indicate a pattern of gradual slowing, not collapse: growth remained robust in both 2012 and 2013, with 2013 matching the 2012 rate, and the report characterized the broader transition as one of structural transformation and orderly moderation rather than emergency contraction (World Bank, n.d.-a; World Bank, 2014). That distinction matters. A slowing economy can still create pressure, but it is different from the kind of sudden

deterioration that would strongly incentivize rapid, high-salience external action for short-term political effect.

The broader official agenda of the period reinforces that interpretation. The Third Plenum communique of November 2013 made clear that reform and development remained central priorities, stating that development was still key to solving China's problems and linking deeper reform to modernization of governance capacity (Communist Party of China [CPC], 2013a). The same period also saw an official emphasis on external stability as a condition for domestic development. At the October 2013 conference on diplomatic work with neighboring countries, Xi stressed the importance of a sound neighboring environment for China's own development and described the surrounding region as strategically significant and stable on the whole (Xi, 2013). In the 2014 Report on the Work of the Government, the State Council likewise stated that China needed a long-term stable international environment for modernization and tied neighborhood diplomacy to mutually beneficial cooperation and development (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014). These contemporaneous official documents are important because they provide pre-choice evidence of the political logic surrounding the AIIB's emergence. Before the October 2014 commitment point, the leadership was already articulating a development-centered and stability-seeking external strategy that is more consistent with institutional statecraft than with coercive disruption.

This does not mean that economic conditions alone explain the AIIB initiative. It does mean, however, that the pre-choice environment appears broadly compatible with a longer-horizon project. Institution-building in development finance typically requires time, negotiation, and organizational design, and in the AIIB case it also involved sustained multilateral consultation and institutional preparation (Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). It is not a strategy designed primarily to generate immediate domestic spectacle. In this sense, the economic context matters not only because China had resources, but because the leadership's domestic priorities in 2012–2014 did not obviously compel a short-horizon

external move. The evidence therefore supports a permissive-context inference: China's domestic economic environment made a patient institutional project feasible enough to be seriously pursued.

Leader Political Security, Elite Management, and Time Horizons

The second component of the argument concerns leader political security. This is the most difficult part of the China case and must be handled carefully. Following Svolik (2012), this thesis treats leader political security as a multidimensional concept shaped by vulnerability to elite threats and mass pressures. In authoritarian settings, however, leader political security is rarely directly observable. For that reason, the task here is not to claim that Xi's political security can be measured with certainty. The more defensible question is whether the 2012–2014 political environment shows signs of acute insecurity severe enough to make rapid coercive external action politically attractive, or whether it instead shows a leadership engaged in consolidation and control while still able to sustain a slower external strategy.

The evidence points to the latter, though with important caveats. The early Xi period involved elite management, anti-corruption enforcement, and institutional centralization. Contemporaneous official and scholarly evidence indicates that Party discipline, anti-corruption, and centralization were treated as major political priorities in this period (CPC, 2013b; Shirk, 2018; Wang & Zeng, 2016). The November 2013 Third Plenum communique announced the creation of a state security committee and explicitly tied social governance, national security, and social stability together (CPC, 2013b). Scholarly accounts interpret these developments not as ordinary administrative housekeeping, but as part of a broader project of power centralization and Party-state strengthening. Wang and Zeng (2016) argue that Xi's anti-corruption campaign and concentration of power were part of a state-building project designed to enhance Party-state capacity. Shirk (2018) likewise characterizes Xi's first term as a move toward stronger personalistic rule, while Saich (2016) suggests that public evaluations of governance in this period did not simply collapse, even as satisfaction varied sharply across levels of government. Taken

together, this suggests a leadership that was actively managing elite politics and legitimacy, but not one clearly trapped in a pre-choice environment of acute fragility.

The same caution applies to social stability and mass pressure. The relevant literature suggests that Xi's China became more controlling and more willing to use coercive tools against protest and dissent, which indicates that stability concerns remained real (Cai & Chen, 2022; Wang et al., 2021). Yet this should not automatically be interpreted as evidence of acute regime fragility. In the present argument, what matters is whether the political environment appears more consistent with a leadership capable of sustaining a delayed-payoff institutional strategy or with one under pressure to seek immediate and dramatic external gains. The available evidence supports a cautious inference: Xi faced genuine elite-management and social-control tasks, but the evidence does not point to a level of insecurity so acute that it would have made a slow and multilateral external strategy politically unsustainable.

This matters for time horizons. If China in 2012–2014 had been facing a sharply deteriorating domestic environment or a visibly fragile leadership position, one would expect stronger incentives toward rapid, highly visible, and domestically dramatic external action. The available evidence does not clearly point in that direction. Instead, it suggests a leadership consolidating authority, deepening reform, and emphasizing a stable external environment for development (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; Xi, 2013). That configuration is more compatible with longer time horizons than with urgent resort to coercive revisionism.

Why Institution-Building Became Politically Feasible and Strategically Attractive

The AIIB literature helps show why this institutional pathway was not merely possible, but attractive. Gu (2017) argues that the AIIB reflected a distinctively Chinese form of multilateralism and met both the needs of China's domestic reforms and the expectation that China would behave as a responsible stakeholder. Chin (2016) emphasizes that the AIIB was not merely a financing device but

also a governance project whose institutional design mattered for credibility and influence. Ren (2016) similarly interprets the AIIB as evidence of China acting as an institution-builder in global governance. Wilson (2019) shows that the AIIB also evolved from a more revisionist proposal into a more status-seeking and legitimacy-conscious institutional project, while Humphrey (2015) stresses the broader development-finance and multilateral-bank context in which the new institution emerged. Callaghan and Hubbard (2016), Yang (2016), and Haga (2021) likewise show, in different ways, that the AIIB was strategically meaningful because it gave China a multilateral channel through which to influence development finance, enhance regional and international standing, and pursue institutional goals through law, membership, and agenda-setting rather than through force. Stephen and Skidmore (2019) further suggest that the AIIB was consequential not only because it created a new institution, but because it helped embed Chinese preferences for state-led development and non-interference in a multilateral setting.

The domestic-mechanism argument adds something different. It helps explain why this strategic form was politically feasible and preferable in the first place. In the pre-choice period, the Chinese leadership was publicly emphasizing development, reform, and the need for a stable regional environment, while also consolidating political control at home (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; Xi, 2013). Under those conditions, a multilateral infrastructure bank offered several advantages. It was externally visible but not militarily escalatory (Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). It aligned with a development-centered foreign policy narrative (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Xi, 2013). It allowed China to accumulate influence gradually through coalition-building and institutional design (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Wilson, 2019). And it offered reputational as well as strategic gains through broader membership, governance compromise, and enhanced international standing (Humphrey, 2015; Wilson, 2019). In other words, the AIIB's appeal lay not only in its international utility, but in its fit with a domestic context that rewarded strategic patience more than immediate confrontation.

This point is important because it separates the chosen institutional pathway from the pre-choice logic that made that outcome attractive. The chapter's argument is not simply that the AIIB later unfolded through a long institutional sequence. It is that, before the October 2014 commitment point, the available evidence was already more consistent with a leadership strategy centered on development, reform under tighter political control, regional stability, and multilateral leverage (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; Wilson, 2019; Xi, 2013). The institutional sequence thereafter matters mainly as confirmation that the chosen pathway was actually followed, not as the main proof of why it was selected.

Assessing the Mechanism

The China case provides cautious but defensible support for the proposed mechanism. The 2012–2014 pre-treatment environment shows slowdown without acute collapse, while the political context suggests consolidation and control rather than severe pre-choice fragility (Cai & Chen, 2022; Shirk, 2018; Wang et al., 2021; Wang & Zeng, 2016; World Bank, n.d.-a; World Bank, 2014). Official rhetoric before the October 2014 MoU emphasized development, reform, and neighborhood stability, which is more consistent with patience and delayed returns than with a short-horizon external move (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; Xi, 2013). The strategic commitment point is also clear enough for process tracing: the institutional option entered the agenda in 2013 and was publicly committed to through the October 2014 MoU (AIIB, 2015a; Ren, 2016).

Rival explanations remain substantial. The AIIB can plausibly be read as a response to slow reform in existing multilateral development banks, as a status-seeking project, as an instrument of regional economic statecraft, or as part of a broader effort to shape global governance (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Gu, 2017; Haga, 2021; Humphrey, 2015; Stephen & Skidmore, 2019; Wilson, 2019; Yang, 2016). The contribution of this chapter is narrower: it shows that a legal,

multilateral, and delayed-payoff pathway was domestically sustainable and politically attractive in this episode.

The strongest conclusion warranted here is therefore one of mechanism plausibility rather than definitive causal demonstration. The China chapter no longer rests simply on the fact that the AIIB later became a multilateral institution. Rather, it shows that China's pre-choice domestic environment was broadly compatible with a slow institutional route and did not strongly favor a coercive one (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; World Bank, 2014; Xi, 2013). On that basis, the case supports H₁ in a cautious but defensible way.

CHAPTER 4

RUSSIA AND CRIMEA: COERCION AS REVISIONIST STRATEGY

This chapter examines Russia's annexation of Crimea as a case of coercion and asks whether the episode fits the domestic-mechanism argument developed in Chapter 2. Its central question is why a rapid, force-backed, and politically salient strategy became feasible and attractive for the Russian leadership in the 2011–2013 pre-treatment period and the early-2014 decision window. To answer that question, the chapter traces the choice of strategic form in the Crimea episode and evaluates whether the available evidence is consistent with a shorter-horizon, higher-risk logic shaped by weaker economic conditions and greater political insecurity. Compared with the China case, the Russia case offers more direct evidence on both pre-choice vulnerability and post-choice domestic payoff (Hale, 2018, 2022; Person, 2017), but geopolitical and ideational explanations remain indispensable.

The Crimea Episode as the Focal Strategic Choice

Crimea is an appropriate case because it provides a clear instance of coercion as a revisionist strategy (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016). Russia did not seek change in this episode by creating new multilateral rules or institutions. Instead, it used force-backed intervention, deniable military presence, and territorial incorporation in a way widely understood as a challenge to prevailing legal and territorial norms (Allison, 2014; Treisman, 2016). Allison (2014) describes Russia's intervention in Crimea and eastern Ukraine as the use of coercion and force to seize control of and destabilize the territory of a neighboring state, while also emphasizing that Moscow advanced contested legal and political justifications for its conduct. Official Russian documents make the strategic sequence equally clear. On March 1, 2014, Putin submitted an appeal to the Federation Council for permission to use the Armed Forces in Ukraine. On March 18, 2014, he delivered the Kremlin address justifying Crimea's accession to Russia, and the same day Russia signed the accession agreement incorporating Crimea and Sevastopol into the Russian Federation (President of Russia, 2014a, 2014b, 2014c). Taken together,

these steps show that the focal strategic pathway was coercive, territorial, and highly visible from the moment of commitment (Allison, 2014; President of Russia, 2014a, 2014b, 2014c).

For process tracing, the key issue is not simply that annexation later occurred. It is the choice to move onto that coercive pathway in early 2014. In the structure of this thesis, the relevant pre-treatment window is 2011–2013, while the strategic commitment point lies in the late-February to March 2014 decision sequence, running through the March 1 request to use force and culminating in the March 18 incorporation acts (President of Russia, 2014a, 2014b, 2014c; Treisman, 2016). This narrower focus is methodologically important because it centers the chapter on the selection of strategic form rather than on the entire subsequent life of the conflict. The question is therefore why the Russian leadership, facing the domestic conditions of 2011–2013, chose this rapid and risky coercive route rather than a slower and less escalatory strategy.

Pre-Choice Domestic Conditions: Economic Slowdown and a Less Permissive Environment

The first component of the argument concerns economic performance. The theoretical claim is not that economic slowdown automatically causes coercion. Rather, the argument is that weaker economic conditions can shorten leaders' effective time horizons by increasing the political value of strategies that produce immediate, visible returns (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988). In the Russian case, the pre-treatment period was not one of catastrophic collapse, but it was clearly less permissive than in the Chinese case. The World Bank reported that Russia's economy grew 4.3 percent in 2011 but only 3.4 percent in 2012 and had slowed in the second half of 2012, while the IMF's 2014 Article IV report stated that the growth slowdown that began in 2011 continued in 2013 and that real GDP growth slowed to 1.3 percent in 2013 because of weak investment (IMF, 2014; World Bank, 2013). This is the kind of macro context that matters for the thesis's mechanism: not full-blown crisis, but a visible deterioration in performance and momentum before the Crimea decision (IMF, 2014; World Bank, 2013).

This point should be interpreted carefully. Slower growth by itself does not explain the Crimea decision. But it does matter because it alters the domestic political context in which leaders assess strategic patience and acceptable risk. A less dynamic economy can make long-horizon strategies with diffuse payoffs harder to sustain politically, especially in a system where legitimacy partly depends on performance and stability (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988). The IMF's 2014 report is especially useful because it ties the slowdown to structural constraints rather than presenting it as a brief fluctuation (IMF, 2014). For the purposes of process tracing, the economic evidence therefore supports an inference of a less permissive domestic environment: Russia entered 2014 under conditions that raised the political value of immediate and salient gains relative to slower and more diffuse returns (Dvir, 2021; IMF, 2014; Putnam, 1988; World Bank, 2013).

Leader Political Insecurity, Protest Legacies, and Shortened Time Horizons

The second component of the argument concerns leader political security. This part of the Russia case offers more direct evidence than is available in the China case because the relevant pressures are more visible. The 2011–2012 protest wave following the parliamentary and presidential elections exposed meaningful mass dissatisfaction and challenged the image of stable regime dominance. Person (2017) argues that it was only after the mass protests following the questionable Duma and presidential elections of 2011–2012 that Putin initiated a significant crackdown on ordinary citizen political activism. Hale (2022) likewise notes that the decline in Putin's approval before Crimea was widely regarded as a significant threat to the regime and links an earlier stage of this decline to the major protest wave of 2011–2012. Treisman (2016) similarly suggests that the Kremlin entered the Crimea decision under pressure and became increasingly prone to risky short-run gambles, even if the regime was not on the verge of collapse. In other words, by the end of the pre-treatment window, Putin's regime had already encountered a visible challenge from below and had begun to respond in ways consistent with heightened concern about political control and legitimacy.

This matters because, in the logic of authoritarian politics, leaders face risks not only from elite rivals but also from mass publics. Svoboda's (2012) framework treats authoritarian control and elite power-sharing as dual problems of regime survival. In Russia's case, the election protests signaled that public discontent could become politically meaningful, while the regime's subsequent response suggested that the leadership took that possibility seriously (Hale, 2018; Person, 2017). The issue is not whether Putin's position was on the verge of collapse. It was not. The issue is whether the domestic political environment was one in which shorter time horizons and demand for salient political payoff became more plausible. Here the evidence is more direct than in the China chapter. The protest legacy, the turn toward greater repression and nationalist-conservative legitimation, and the regime's sensitivity to public mood all point toward a leadership that had reason to value strategies capable of producing rapid and dramatic political effects (Hale, 2018; Person, 2017).

The strongest evidence comes from the domestic political payoff of Crimea itself. Putin's approval ratings surged dramatically after Crimea (Hale, 2018, 2022; Levada Center, n.d.). Hale's (2018, 2022) work shows that the annexation produced a major and durable rally effect, while Levada Center's (n.d.) monthly approval series shows that, after spending much of 2012–2013 and early 2014 in the 60s, Putin's rating rose from 65 percent in January 2014 and 69 percent in February to 80 percent in March 2014, the month of Crimea's incorporation into Russia, and then remained above 80 percent for much of the period that followed. Although post-choice payoff does not prove *ex ante* motive by itself, it is highly relevant to process tracing because it demonstrates that coercive action in this episode actually delivered the kind of rapid, visible domestic reward that the mechanism would predict. Levada Center's (n.d.) long-running approval series is consistent with this broader pattern of sustained post-Crimea popularity. In this respect, the Russia case provides unusually direct evidence that the coercive choice was followed by a large and politically meaningful rally.

Why Coercion Became Politically Feasible and Strategically Attractive

Official Russian rhetoric around Crimea helps clarify why coercion became attractive. In his March 18, 2014 address, Putin framed Crimea in terms of history, compatriots, national unity, and justice (President of Russia, 2014b). The formal appeal to the Federation Council on March 1 likewise shows that the leadership was prepared to move quickly onto a force-backed path (President of Russia, 2014a). These official steps matter because they reveal a strategy designed for immediate political salience, not for delayed institutional returns. Unlike the AIIB, Crimea did not require lengthy coalition-building, formal multilateral negotiation, or gradual accumulation of legitimacy through governance design. Its payoff logic was immediate: it offered a dramatic display of strength, a nationalist frame that could consolidate support, and a direct answer to the regime's need for political momentum after the protest era and amid economic slowdown (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017; Treisman, 2016).

The domestic-mechanism argument complements rather than replaces geopolitical explanations here. The Crimea decision can clearly be interpreted in strategic, historical, legal, and regional-security terms. Allison (2014) emphasizes that Russia's conduct in Ukraine reflected overlapping explanations rather than a single cause, while Götz (2015) shows why a geopolitical account can explain the salience of Ukraine and the strategic importance of Crimea. Treisman (2016), by contrast, is especially useful in emphasizing contingency, improvisation, and Putin's political gamble. But the domestic argument adds something important. It helps explain why, among different possible forms of revisionist action, a rapid and visible coercive move became politically feasible and attractive at this particular moment. Under conditions of slower growth, a protest legacy, and heightened sensitivity to regime legitimacy, coercion offered the possibility of immediate symbolic success and public rallying in a way that slower and less escalatory strategies could not (Hale, 2018; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017). That is what makes the Russia case especially useful for evaluating the thesis's mechanism.

Assessing the Mechanism

The Russia case provides stronger evidence for the proposed mechanism. Before Crimea, economic growth had slowed substantially and the domestic political environment still carried the legacy of the 2011–2012 protest wave (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017; World Bank, 2013). The relevant time-horizon implications are also clearer: immediate and visible political payoff had become more valuable, and the post-Crimea rally shows that coercive action in fact delivered such payoff (Hale, 2018, 2022; Levada Center, n.d.; Person, 2017). The strategic commitment point is sharply bounded in the late-February to March 2014 sequence, especially the March 1 appeal to use force and the March 18 incorporation acts (President of Russia, 2014a, 2014b, 2014c; Treisman, 2016).

Rival explanations remain important here as well. Crimea can be interpreted through geopolitics, military strategy, Russian nationalism, identity, and disputes over the post-Cold War order (Allison, 2014; Götz, 2015; Treisman, 2016). The chapter's narrower contribution is to show that the domestic environment made a high-risk, high-salience coercive move politically attractive at this moment. Under conditions of slower growth, a protest legacy, and heightened sensitivity to regime legitimacy, coercion offered immediate symbolic success and public rallying in a way that slower strategies could not (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017).

The strongest conclusion warranted here is again one of mechanism plausibility, but with more direct evidentiary support than in the China case. The evidence is broadly consistent with H₂: weaker economic conditions and greater political insecurity shortened time horizons and increased the attractiveness of a rapid, visible, and risky coercive strategy (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017; Treisman, 2016; World Bank, 2013). The chapter does not claim that domestic variables alone caused Crimea, but it does show that domestic vulnerability and political payoff are integral to understanding why coercion became the dominant strategic form in this episode (Hale, 2018, 2022; Person, 2017).

CHAPTER 5

COMPARATIVE DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

This chapter brings together the findings from the China–AIIB and Russia–Crimea cases and evaluates what the domestic-mechanism argument can and cannot explain. Across the two cases, the main pattern is clear: more permissive economic conditions and relatively higher leader political security were more compatible with institution-building, whereas weaker economic conditions and relatively lower leader political security were more compatible with coercion. The comparison does not establish a universal law, but it does support the thesis’s central claim in a cautious comparative sense and clarifies the role of domestic conditions alongside systemic, geopolitical, and ideational factors rather than replacing them.

Comparing the Two Cases

The most important comparative finding is that the two cases differed not only in strategic outcome but also in the domestic political logic surrounding the choice of strategy. In the China case, the 2012–2014 pre-treatment period showed economic moderation without acute collapse, official emphasis on reform and development, and a domestic political environment marked by consolidation and control without clear evidence of severe pre-choice political fragility (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People’s Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; World Bank, 2014, World Bank, n.d.-a; Xi, 2013). The available evidence therefore suggested a domestic context compatible with strategic patience, coalition-building, and tolerance for delayed returns (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People’s Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; World Bank, 2014, World Bank, n.d.-a; Xi, 2013). That context fit the AIIB pathway, which required multilateral negotiation, institutional design, and gradual accumulation of authority through law and governance (AIIB, 2015a, 2015b, 2016; Chin, 2016; Gu, 2017; Ren, 2016).

The Russia case presented a different domestic configuration. In the 2011–2013 pre-treatment period, economic growth slowed substantially, and the domestic political environment still carried the legacy of the 2011–2012 protest wave (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017; World Bank, 2013). That context did not amount to imminent regime collapse, but it did suggest a less permissive domestic environment in which immediate and visible political gains had greater value (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017). In contrast to the AIIB case, the Crimea pathway offered rapid symbolic payoff, a visible assertion of strength, and a dramatic nationalist frame (Allison, 2014; President of Russia, 2014b; Treisman, 2016). The post-Crimea rally effect further reinforced the mechanism’s plausibility by showing that coercive action actually generated the kind of politically salient domestic reward that the argument would predict (Hale, 2018, 2022; Levada Center, n.d.).

The comparison therefore suggests that the thesis’s mechanism finds support across the cases in an asymmetrical but meaningful way. In China, the evidence supports a permissive-context inference: more permissive economic conditions and a domestic political environment not marked by severe pre-choice fragility were more consistent with institution-building and did not strongly favor coercion (Shirk, 2018; State Council of the People’s Republic of China, 2014; Wang & Zeng, 2016; World Bank, 2014, n.d.-a; Xi, 2013). In Russia, the evidence is stronger and more direct: weaker economic performance, a protest legacy, and the political value of immediate symbolic payoff were more clearly aligned with coercion (Hale, 2018, 2022; IMF, 2014; Person, 2017; World Bank, 2013). The result is not a perfectly symmetrical pair of evidentiary demonstrations, but a structured comparison in which both cases point in the same theoretical direction while differing in evidentiary strength (Beach & Pedersen, 2019; Collier, 2011; George & Bennett, 2005).

What This Thesis Explains

This thesis explains variation in the strategic form of revisionist behavior across specific episodes. It does not explain revisionism as a permanent national trait, nor does it claim that domestic conditions alone determine whether a state becomes revisionist in the first place. Its narrower claim is

that domestic conditions help shape the strategic form revisionist behavior takes, whether through institution-building or coercion (Cooley et al., 2019; Dvir, 2021; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012).

That scope condition matters because the same state may draw on different revisionist repertoires in different contexts. China's AIIB initiative and Russia's annexation of Crimea are therefore treated not as expressions of stable national essences, but as bounded strategic episodes in which leaders selected among different instruments. The thesis is best understood as a comparative, process-tracing study of mechanism plausibility rather than as a universal theory of state behavior (Beach & Pedersen, 2019; Collier, 2011; George & Bennett, 2005).

The domestic mechanism operates through time horizons and risk calculations. Economic performance and leader political security matter not as simple structural causes, but because they shape perceptions of urgency, acceptable risk, and the political costs of waiting (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). Under more favorable conditions, leaders can sustain slower strategies whose returns are indirect and delayed; under weaker economic conditions and greater political insecurity, rapid and visible gains become more attractive even when they carry substantial external risks (Dvir, 2021; Putnam, 1988; Svolik, 2012). Table 1 summarizes how those differences were linked to contrasting strategic forms of revisionist behavior in the two cases.

Table 1. Comparative Summary of Domestic Conditions and Strategic Form of Revisionist Behavior in the Two Cases

Dimension	China: AIIB	Russia: Crimea
Focal episode	Creation of the AIIB	Annexation of Crimea
Pre-treatment window	2012–2014	2011–2013
Economic context	Economic moderation without acute collapse; growth slowed but remained relatively robust	Substantial slowdown and a less permissive macroeconomic environment
Leader political security	More indirect evidence of consolidation, elite management, and social control, but no clear evidence of severe pre-choice fragility	More direct evidence of protest legacy, regime sensitivity, and political insecurity
Time-horizon logic	More compatible with strategic patience, delayed returns, and coalition-building	More compatible with urgency, immediate symbolic payoff, and greater risk tolerance
Strategic commitment point	October 24, 2014 MoU signing, following the 2013 launch of the initiative	Late-February to March 2014 decision sequence, especially the March 1 force appeal and March 18 incorporation acts
Observed strategic form	Institution-building	Coercion
Political payoff logic	Indirect and delayed gains through institutional design, membership expansion, and governance authority	Immediate and salient symbolic gains, nationalist framing, and a large domestic rally effect
Mechanism fit	Consistent but more indirect support for H ₁	Stronger and more direct support for H ₂
Main limitation	Leader political security is less directly observable; inference is more indirect	The case remains multi-causal despite stronger evidence for the domestic mechanism

Limitations

Several limitations should be acknowledged clearly. The first concerns the number of cases. A two-case comparison cannot establish a universal law, and this thesis does not claim to do so. Its contribution lies instead in disciplined within-case analysis and cross-case comparison. The cases were selected because they are substantively important and vary clearly on the dependent variable, but the limited number of cases necessarily constrains the scope of inference (George & Bennett, 2005).

A second limitation concerns the observability of leader political security. This problem is especially pronounced in the China case. In authoritarian systems, leader political security is rarely directly observable, and some of the relevant evidence must be inferred from elite-management efforts, anti-corruption campaigns, social-control practices, and broader signs of regime consolidation or vulnerability. As a result, the China chapter supports only a cautious conclusion that the domestic political environment was broadly compatible with a longer-horizon institutional strategy and did not strongly favor coercion (Saich, 2016; Shirk, 2018; Wang & Zeng, 2016). By contrast, the Russia case offers more direct evidence of pre-choice insecurity and post-choice domestic payoff, which is why the evidentiary fit for the mechanism is stronger there (Hale, 2018, 2022; Person, 2017).

A third limitation is that both cases are plainly multi-causal. In the Russia case, geopolitical, legal, ideational, and historical explanations remain indispensable (Allison, 2014; Götz, 2015; Treisman, 2016). Allison's (2014) account is especially important because it explicitly shows that Crimea cannot be reduced to a single motive or cause. In the China case, the AIIB can be understood through governance innovation, status-seeking, institutional dissatisfaction, development-finance gaps, or broader efforts to reshape global governance (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Gu, 2017; Humphrey, 2015; Ren, 2016; Stephen & Skidmore, 2019; Wilson, 2019; Yang, 2016). The thesis does not displace these explanations. Its claim is narrower: domestic conditions help clarify why one strategic form was politically sustainable and attractive in each episode.

A fourth limitation concerns the concept of revisionism itself. As Kustermans et al. (2023) emphasize, revisionism is analytically and politically contested, and classification depends on how international order is interpreted and what kinds of behavior are socially recognized as challenges to that order. This thesis addresses that problem by adopting an episode-level dependent variable focused on strategic form rather than trying to resolve every interpretive debate about revisionism in general. Even so, the classification of cases such as the AIIB as revisionist remains open to reasonable disagreement, which is why the empirical analysis has focused more on the contrast between institution-building and coercion than on categorical claims about fixed state identities (Cooley et al., 2019; He et al., 2021; Kustermans et al., 2023).

Implications for the Study of Revisionist States

The thesis has several implications for the study of revisionist states. First, it suggests that scholars should not assume that dissatisfied major powers will necessarily prefer coercion. Institution-building can itself be a strategically consequential form of contestation that operates through rules, governance structures, membership coalitions, and authority in multilateral settings (Cooley et al., 2019; Goddard, 2018; He et al., 2021). The AIIB case illustrates that institutional strategies can be central rather than peripheral to revisionist politics (Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016; Wilson, 2019). This matters because it broadens the range of behaviors that should count as strategically important forms of order contestation.

Second, the thesis suggests that domestic conditions can be integrated into revisionism analysis not as a rival to systemic theory, but as a mechanism shaping strategic form. Putnam's (1988) two-level framework indicates that external strategy is shaped by domestic constraints and political sustainability, while Svobik's (2012) framework highlights how survival incentives and elite or mass threats shape leaders' calculations. Taken together, these perspectives suggest that domestic political vulnerability and time horizons can serve as important scope conditions for strategic form choice (Dvir, 2021; Putnam,

1988; Svolik, 2012). Future work on revisionism would therefore benefit from taking domestic political incentives more seriously when explaining why leaders pursue institutional or coercive pathways.

Third, the thesis has a methodological implication. Typological work and process tracing are complementary rather than competing approaches. Typologies help specify the dependent variable and the possible strategic forms that revisionist behavior can take, while process tracing helps evaluate whether a hypothesized mechanism plausibly connects domestic conditions to strategic choice within particular cases (Beach & Pedersen, 2019; Collier, 2011; Cooley et al., 2019; George & Bennett, 2005). In that sense, the study shows the value of combining a clear episode-level dependent variable with a mechanism-centered small-N comparative design. It also suggests that future research could extend this approach by adding more cases, incorporating additional revisionist repertoires, or pairing qualitative process tracing with broader comparative analysis.

Finally, the thesis has a policy-relevant implication for governments and institutions seeking to prevent escalation and respond to revisionist challenges. Anticipating revisionist behavior requires attention not only to shifts in the international distribution of power, but also to domestic political conditions that shape leaders' time horizons. The Crimea case suggests that coercive action can generate substantial domestic political payoff, and that external cost imposition may be less effective than expected when the domestic political benefits of dramatic action are high (Alexseev & Hale, 2020; Hale, 2018, 2022). The AIIB case suggests that challengers may also pursue influence through multilateral institutions and governance design, which means that order contestation can proceed through institutional innovation rather than military escalation alone (Callaghan & Hubbard, 2016; Chin, 2016; Ren, 2016). These different strategic forms imply different escalation dynamics and therefore call for different analytic, deterrent, and policy responses.

Conclusion

This thesis has argued that revisionist behavior is not strategically uniform and that variation in its form can be analyzed across specific episodes. It proposed a domestic-mechanism argument in which

economic performance and leader political security shape leaders' time horizons and risk calculations, thereby influencing the strategic form revisionist behavior takes, whether through institution-building or coercion.

The comparison of China's AIIB initiative and Russia's annexation of Crimea provides cautious support for that argument. In China, the evidence points to a more permissive domestic environment and a longer-horizon logic compatible with institution-building. In Russia, the evidence more strongly points to a less permissive environment, greater political insecurity, and a shorter-horizon logic that made coercion especially attractive.

The most defensible final conclusion is therefore modest but meaningful. Domestic conditions do not replace systemic or geopolitical explanations of revisionist behavior, but they help explain why different strategic forms of revisionist behavior become politically feasible and attractive in different episodes. By shifting attention from revisionism as a general label to variation in the strategic form revisionist behavior takes, this thesis shows that institution-building and coercion should not be treated as analytically interchangeable. It also identifies domestic conditions as an important part of the explanation for variation in revisionist strategy by showing how economic performance and leader political security shape leaders' time horizons, risk calculations, and strategic choices. More broadly, the argument suggests that anticipating and responding to revisionist challenges requires attention not only to shifts in international power, but also to the domestic conditions that make different strategic pathways more likely.

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